If newspapers are any barometer of popular sentiment, a glance at *The Times of India*'s front-page headlines on post-budget days between 2014 and 2019 provides a ballpark sense of how perceptions of the Modi government's economics changed over time. If 2014 ('FM makes money for you') and 2015 were long on euphoria and hope ('Make it, India'), by 2016, the winds were clearly changing ('Glowing in the wind', 'But it's bad news for the "rich" as govt shifts focus'). By 2017, the Modi government had clearly started veering leftwards ('Wooing have-nots, hitting have-notes') and by 2018-19, it was in full election-mode ('It all adds up to 2019'; '20,19 … Modi goes full steam'). In Modi's second term, the budget frontpage headlines remained lukewarm ('FM stumps rich, bats for investment' in 2019 and 'New tax deal for the common man' in 2020, or 'Long, wobbly flight to recovery' in *The Economic Times*).[98]

Because Narendra Modi was seen by many as a reformist economic figure when he swept to power in 2014, it is useful to check just how keen his government has been on reform and change. A verdict on this is best left to the economists, but one way to decipher it is to use discourse analysis, that is, pay closer attention to what various finance ministers have been saying over the years.

Data scientist Rishabh Srivastava and I analysed all the budget speeches by finance ministers from 1951 to 2020 to create word clouds of what they considered important and to spot patterns of change over time. A few key themes stand out about the Modi government in this analysis. We found that the Vajpayee government's finance ministers between 1999 and 2004 focused on words like 'disinvestment' and 'privatisation' about twice as much as Modi's finance ministers (see Figure 10.10) and about the same as UPA ministers. The word 'privatisation' itself first found its maiden budget speech mention in 1992-93, just after liberalisation in 1991. In the middle of Vajpayee's tenure in 2001-02, 'privatisation' had the most number of mentions (twelve). Later, between 2005-06 and 2008-09 (during the global financial crisis), and 2013–2015, there was no mention of it at all. The word was mentioned only four times in the 2019-20 budget.